



WIRED: Evaluating a smartphone-accessible app to improve clinical trial recruitment and staff engagement in the ED

Authors: Eoin Macdonald-Nethercott , Jewel Inapan, Susie Hardwick, Ed Barnard, Adrian Boyle.

Institution: Cambridge University Hospitals NHS Foundation Trust

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 eoin.macdonald-nethercott@nhs.net Mailto link:



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Aims, objectives and background:

Recruitment to emergency medicine clinical trials is hampered by time pressure and fragmented information. We developed and evaluated a smartphone-accessible web app to study whether it would enhance staff engagement and patient enrollment.

The WIRED ("Web accessed Information to Improve Recruitment to research studies in Emergency Departments") smartphone web-app provided easily accessible information on studies, in order to help staff rapidly access the information they need.

The Intervention

The WIRED app was accessible via QR codes on departmental posters and staff key fobs, viewable as a website and installable as an app. To ensure rapid utility during high-acuity shifts, the app requires no login. It has:

- Immediate access to inclusion/exclusion criteria.
- Standardised, step-by-step recruitment "how-to" guides.
- Direct links to online delegation logs and training materials.

Method and design

We introduced the app at five UK Emergency Departments (two tertiary and three acute care hospitals). We collected monthly enrolment data and staff delegation log numbers for six months prior to introduction, and six months after. Anonymised control data from twenty two matched hospitals not using the app was obtained, with permission, from the NIHR Open Data Platform.

The low numbers involved, and rising baseline for both groups, made statistical analysis of the result impractical.

Analytics showed average user session times of 10–20 seconds, consistent with rapid point-of-care decision-making, rather than app exploration.



Results and conclusion

Results showed that introducing the app was associated with a 31% increase in the number of staff added to delegation logs

Compared to controls, WIRED sites showed an increase in recruitment equivalent to 1.33 extra patients per month per site after introduction of the app.

In questionnaire responses, all the research teams felt that the app had made a positive difference to recruitment to research studies at their site.

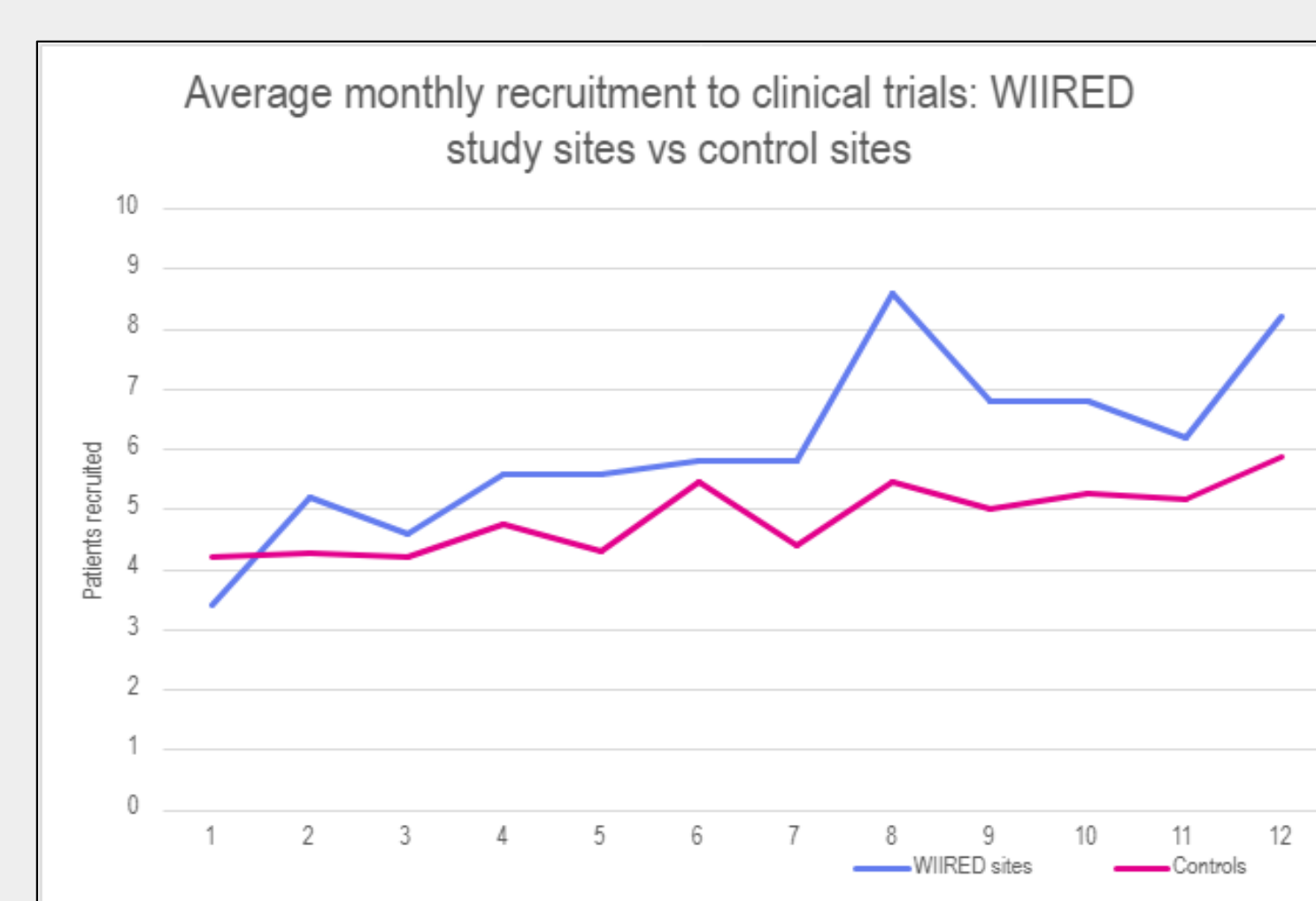


Fig 1: Mean monthly recruitment per site per month. Month 1 is August 2025, the app was published at the beginning of month 6, and was introduced to the teams between months 6 and 7

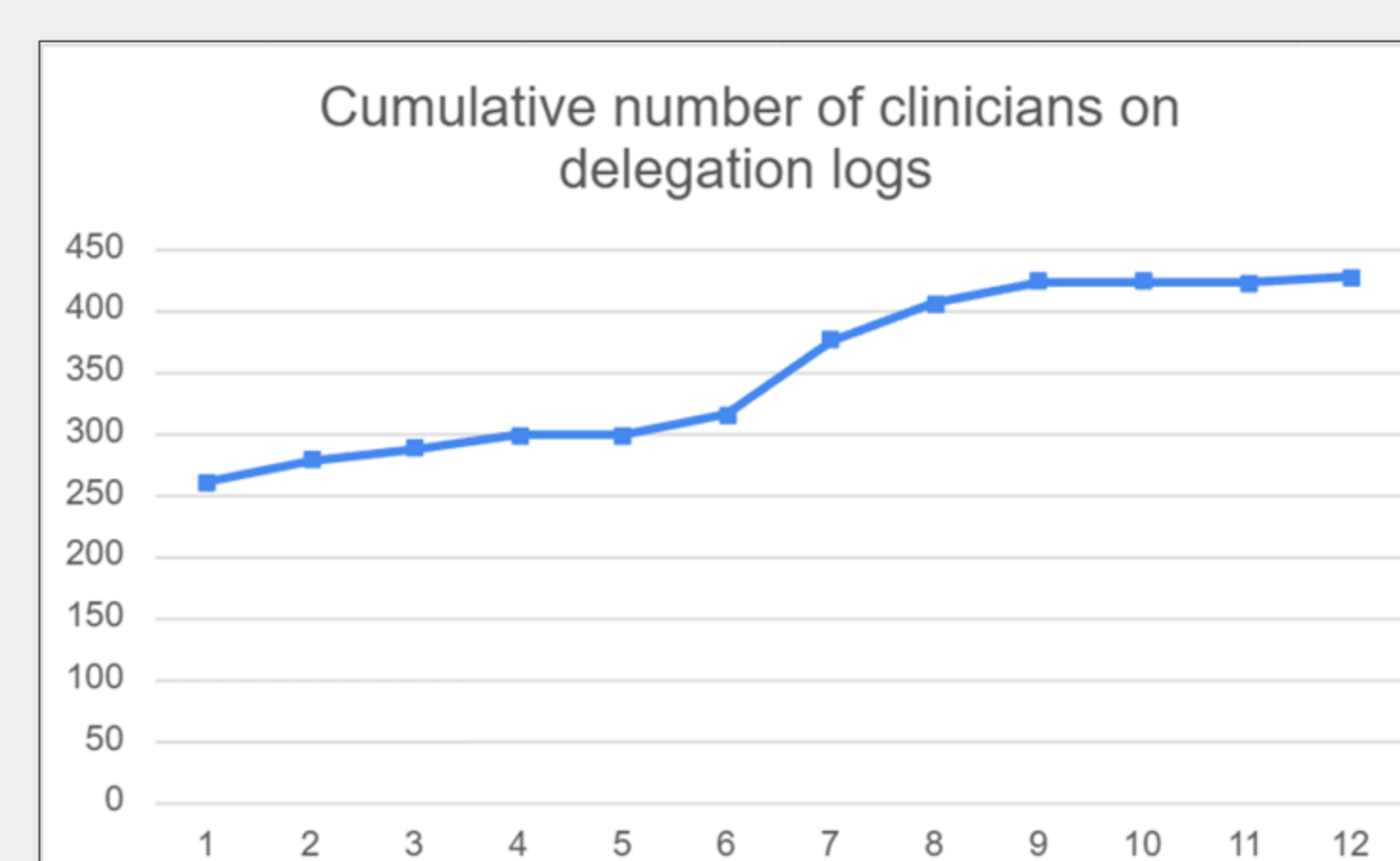


Fig 2: Cumulative delegation log numbers over the same period

Conclusion

This proof-of-concept project suggests that the right information, easily accessible at the point of care, can improve staff engagement and research recruitment in busy EDs, but that promotion needs to be ongoing until the app is fully embedded in routine practice.

The results would support a trial with wider deployment and a longer evaluation period to assess the potential of the WIRED app to support EM staff, and improve patients access to clinical trials.

